Mausoleum of Cyrus the Great and the royal necropolis at Naqsh-e Rustam (which included the tombs of Darius the Great and Xerxes I amongst others), but the nomadic peoples of Central Asia that the Mughals descended from did not have an elaborate tradition of mausoleums. Genghis Khan famously requested an unmarked grave, and the Tibetan Buddhists allowed their remains to be devoured by birds.

However, when the Mughals entered India, they wholeheartedly adopted the Persian burial traditions, and even before the Taj Mahal, there were several Mughal garden tombs. The Emperor Humayun, Babur's son and Akbar's father, built the first one in Delhi, creating the style of garden tombs in 1570. For Humayun, the architects designed the charbagh style of garden and placed his mausoleum in its center, much like the positioning of the Taj Mahal. Furthermore, like the Taj itself, Humayun's mausoleum was topped with an onion dome and flanked by chhartis, and it is also recognized as a UNESCO World Heritage Site[10]. Akbar's Tomb can be found in Agra near the Taj Mahal, and it also possesses a deeply Islamic-influenced façade, including an iwan gate and two minaret-like towers[11].



Humayun's Tomb. Picture by Muhammad Mahdi Karim

Another tomb predecessor was the mausoleum of Jahangir, the father of Shah Jahan himself. Located in Lahore, Pakistan, it is also located within an enclosed charbagh garden, but instead of having a central domed structure, it is a low structure with minaret-like towers at each of the four corners. Jahangir's tomb dates to 1605 and is decorated in a style of mosaics and tiles